

The Bengal Renaissance

In the eastern region of Bengal, the first railway proposal came from the Calcutta and Saugor Railway and Harbour Company in 1836 to construct a line from George's Point to Calcutta. However, with high construction costs and no support from the Government in Britain beyond a land grant, the project could not be executed.

In the 1830s, Dwarkanath Tagore, a businessman from Calcutta, bought collieries in Raneegunge. To facilitate transportation of coal, his company Carr, Tagore, and Co undertook a survey for a rail line between Raneegunge and Salkea Ghat. One of the first of its kind, the survey was backed by prominent individuals, including British railway engineer Rowland Macdonald Stephenson. These advocates of the railways observed the potential of a line in the east for coal that was currently being transported through canals. In 1841, Stephenson thought of connecting Calcutta via a railway line with the North-West Frontier. He focussed on this, not for the coal but, because the railway line would cross the Indo-Gangetic plains, which were densely populated. Stephenson was one of the most prominent advocates of a rail system in India.

Historian Dipesh Chakrabarty argues that it was Stephenson's strategy to publish articles and reports about railways to bring "railway consciousness" to Bengal. He writes that it was a time when political awareness had started to hit the region. While the attitude of the locals towards the railways has not been explored in detail, Chakrabarty provides some correspondence between Stephenson and Indian men to suggest that they were in favour of the enterprise. He states that this group of individuals were a part of the Bengali elite and while they may not have promoted colonialism, they were entrenched in it through economic pursuits. This might have been why, Chakrabarty theorizes, they backed the railways in India.

A detailed proposal

Soon after the first proposal in Bengal, some members of the EIC looked at the possibility of a rail route connecting ports across the Indian peninsula as a shorter route to China. Railway engineer Charles